Next, I move on to the 10-Year Financial Summary, located on , to get a look at the ten-year picture. I discover that there are 511 million shares outstanding. I can also see that the number has been reduced in each of the past two years. This means that Ford has been buying back its own shares, another positive step.

Dividing the $8.35 billion in cash and cash assets by the 511 million shares outstanding, I conclude that there's $16.30 in net cash to go along with every share of Ford. Why this is important will be apparent in the next chapter.

After that, I turn to...already this is getting complicated. If you don't want to proceed with this exercise, and you'd rather read about Henry Ford, then ask your broker whether Ford is buying back shares, whether cash exceeds long-term debt, and how much cash there is per share!

Let's be realistic. I'm not about to lead you on a wild-goose chase through the trails of the accounts. There are important numbers that will help you follow companies, and if you get them from the annual reports, fine. If you don't get them from the annual reports, you can get them from S&P reports, from your broker, or from *Value Line.*

Value Line is easier to read than a balance sheet, so if you've never looked at any of this, start there. It tells you about cash and debt, summarizes the long-term record so you can see what happened during the last recession, whether earnings are on the upswing, whether dividends have always been paid, etc. Finally, it rates companies for financial strength on a simple scale of 1 to 5, giving you a rough idea of a company's ability to withstand adversity. (There's also a rating system for the "timeliness" of stocks, but I don't pay attention to that.)

I'm putting aside the annual report for now. Let's instead consider the important numbers one by one on their own and not struggle further with finding them here.